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AMID YOUTH MENTAL HEALTH CRISIS, CALIFORNIA AND NBA CHAMPION TEAM UP ON NEW LAW TO GET COACHES INTO THE GAME

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SACRAMENTO, Calif., Oct. 2 -- The California State Assembly Democratic Caucus issued the following news release:

SACRAMENTO, CA -This week, California Governor Gavin Newsom signed Assembly Bill (AB) 1626, bipartisan legislation that will put mental health and substance use disorder training in the hands of youth sports coaches.

"For many young people, timely mental health support can be transformative," saidAssemblymember Jesse Gabriel (D-Encino). "Coaches are trusted mentors who are often among the first to recognize when a young person is struggling or in crisis. AB 1626 will give youth sports coaches the tools and training they need to recognize warning signs, respond appropriately, and connect young athletes with support. I'm grateful to Steph Curry and our incredible coalition for championing this important effort, and to Governor Newsom for signing AB 1626 into law."

"I'm grateful for all the coaches who have helped me build confidence and resilience, on and off the court,"said Stephen Curry, NBA Champion. "Through Eat. Learn. Play., we've seen what's possible when coaches have the training and resources to support a young athlete's well-being, not just their game. Every kid deserves that kind of coach, and we've been proud to make investments to ensure coaches in Oakland have the tools to be a great leader. Policies like Assemblymember Jesse Gabriel's help create a strong foundation for coaching practices that can make a lasting impact in an athlete's life."

For coaches across California, AB 1626 turns good intentions into real preparation. It requires K-12 sports coaches to complete training on recognizing the warning signs of depression, anxiety, eating disorders, substance use disorders, and suicidal ideation - and on how to connect a struggling student athlete to resources. It also directs the California Department of Education to build a model training that recreational and club coaches statewide can use to do the same.

Authored by Assemblymembers Jesse Gabriel (D-Encino), Blanca Pacheco (D-Downey), and Jacqui Irwin (D-Thousand Oaks), AB 1626 passed the State Legislature with overwhelming bipartisan support.

A Crisis Playing Out on California's Fields and Courts

The numbers behind AB 1626 tell a stark story. Studies show that teenagers throughout the state are struggling with mental health issues at an increasing rate. More isolated than ever before, California's young men and boys have experienced an alarming rise in suicide rates and feel more disconnected from school, work, and relationships. Nearly one in four men under 30 report having no close friends at all. Meanwhile, young female athletes face their own elevated risks of depression, anxiety, body image struggles, and eating disorders.

Coaches are often uniquely positioned to catch the warning signs, as they see young athletes for numerous hours each week, through wins, losses, and everything in between - and they're frequently the first to notice when something is wrong. Yet only one in five coaches report feeling highly confident in their ability to support a student dealing with a mental health or substance use disorder, and four in five say they feel less than fully prepared. Left without guidance, coaches may miss the moment to step in, or at worst, make a difficult situation harder, as stigma keeps students from speaking up.

Backed by Champions On and Off the Field

AB 1626 was sponsored by the California Alliance of Children and Family Services, Mental Health America of

California, the Play Equity Fund, and the California Commission on the Status of Women and Girls, and backed by a broad and diverse coalition that includes State Superintendent of Public Instruction Tony Thurmond, the San Francisco Giants, U.S. Soccer Foundation, San Francisco 49ers, NAMI California, the American Academy of Pediatrics of California, the Association of California School Administrators, and dozens of other education, youth, and mental health organizations.

"This bill is about turning awareness into life-saving action," saidAssemblywoman Jacqui Irwin (D-Thousand Oaks). "The community I represent in Ventura County lost a remarkable person when the life of Sarah Shulze was tragically cut short by suicide in 2022. Sarah was a talented multi-event runner, and her loss underscores the urgent need to better equip the adults our students trust to recognize and respond to mental health warning signs."

"As we work to address the youth mental health crisis, we must look at the full circle of adults who support our students," saidAssemblywoman Blanca Pacheco (D-Downey). "Coaches are trusted mentors who see student athletes in high-pressure moments, yet many don't have the tools to respond to mental health challenges. I'm glad to partner on AB 1626, in coordination with my bill, AB 1665, to equip coaches to recognize when a student is struggling and connect them to support."

"We are proud to support AB 1626 and its focus on equipping coaches with the tools to better support the mental health and wellbeing of young athletes. Through our work with partners like CalHOPE, Counseling and Support Services for Youth (CASSY), and Beyond Sport, we've seen firsthand the impact coaches can have on improving mental health outcomes in young people. By further strengthening these relationships and resources across the state, we can help create safer, more supportive environments where every young athlete has the opportunity to thrive."-Justin Prettyman, Executive Vice President, Philanthropy and Executive Director, 49ers Foundation

"Coaches have a unique window into young lives, from the quiet moments in the locker rooms, to hours at practice and the emotion of game days. Coaches can be the first to notice when a young person is struggling or wondering if they belong, and they can be the first to ask, 'Will that young person come back tomorrow?' AB 1626 equips coaches with the tools and training to meet young people where they are, support their mental health, and create teams where they feel seen and included. We thank Assemblymember Jesse Gabriel for authoring this important legislation, and Governor Gavin Newsom for signing it."- Renata Simril, President of the Play Equity Fund

"AB 1626 is a transformative step to support California's youth, especially girls. By providing coaches with mental health training, we ensure that every young athlete has a trusted adult who can recognize distress, foster a positive team culture, and connect youth to the support they need. Research shows how invaluable the youth sport experience is for girls; building confidence, self-esteem, emotional well-being. Coaches are often the first to notice when a young person is struggling, and this bill equips them with valuable resources and training they need to recognize and intervene if they see a red flag. Having coaches tuned in to any signs helps not derail a young woman before her journey even begins. We thank Assemblymember Jesse Gabriel for introducing the legislation and co-sponsors CA Alliance of Child and Family Services as well as Mental Health America for their support of the bill. Every child deserves an advocate in their lives who is prepared to nurture both their physical and mental well-being."- Darcy Totten, Executive Director of the California Commission on the Status of Women and Girls

"Coaches are often among the most trusted adults in a student's life, and this bill ensures they have the training to recognize when a young athlete is struggling and connect them to the right support. AB 1626 strengthens the safety net around our student-athletes by equipping coaches to foster positive team cultures, respond with care, and make timely referrals to qualified mental health professionals. As State Superintendent of Public Instruction, I thank Assemblymember Jesse Gabriel for his leadership in advancing a measure that supports student well-being both on and off the field and extends that same support to youth sports organizations across California." -California State Superintendent of Public Instruction, Tony Thurmond

"Our young people don't experience life in silos, so our support system shouldn't be either. We must meet youth where they are, and AB 1626 helps us accomplish that. Coaches are on the front lines and notice when there are changes in a student athlete's behavior, stress, and well-being. Equipping coaches with the appropriate tools to identify, respond, and support youth creates a proactive system of care that is youth-centered and culturally

responsive, improving their long-term mental health and wellness. AB 1626 is an important step toward strengthening California's behavioral health continuum of care for youth and represents the type of investment California urgently needs. Mental Health America of California is grateful for Assemblymember Gabriel's commitment to reshaping systems of care to reflect the diverse experiences of youth and help close gaps in access to quality services and supports."- Tiffany Murphy, Chief Operations Officer, Mental Health America of California

"With Governor Newsom's signature on AB 1626, California is writing a new chapter in the mental health playbook for our youth with real investment in prevention, not just talk. With training to identify mental health and substance use challenges and connect youth with support, coaches can be trusted adults on the field and lifelines off it. The California Alliance members who serve children, youth, and families every day were proud to team up with Assemblymember Jesse Gabriel to co-sponsor AB 1626 and are deeply grateful for Gov. Newsom for signing it into law."- Adrienne Shilton, Senior Vice President of Public Policy and Strategy, California Alliance of Child and Family Services

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